

Good morning everyone,

Have you ever noticed how strange airports are?

Thousands of people.

Different languages.

Different destinations.

Some are saying goodbye.

Some are saying hello.

Some are rushing to catch a flight.

Others are sitting by a window, wondering what awaits them on the other side.

And yet, somehow, for a few hours, all of them share the same space.

When I first thought about what I wanted to say today, I realised that ICC reminds me a lot of an airport.

Every year, students arrive carrying different stories, different cultures, different ambitions, and different expectations.

Some arrive with a plan

Others arrive hoping they'll figure out one

But for a brief moment, all of us find ourselves in the same place, beginning a journey.

And maybe that's what makes a university so special.

It's one of the rare places in life where the future entrepreneur sits beside the future scientist.

Where someone from Bangalore becomes friends with someone from Bangkok.

Where people who would have never met otherwise suddenly become part of each other's stories.

And that's why ICC means so much to me personally.

Because when I first came to CHRIST,

I was nervous.

A little overwhelmed.

And if I'm being completely honest, a little homesick too.

Like many students, I had left behind the comfort of familiar faces and familiar places.

Everything was new.

The campus was bigger than I expected.

The people seemed to know exactly where they were going.

I didn't.

Not even close.

But somewhere in the middle of all that uncertainty, I found ICC,

Here I found People who invited me into conversations.

Here, I found People who became friends.

People who made this campus feel a little less intimidating and a little more like home.

And, What I love most about ICC is that it's impossible to describe with a single event.

It's leadership camps and rural exposure programmes.

It's student exchange programs and cultural celebrations.

It's stalls, performances, props being built.

It's learning how to lead, how to collaborate, how to adapt, and occasionally how to survive on very little sleep before an event.

And through all of that, it somehow manages to turn experiences into memories.

We create spaces where people can learn about one another beyond what is written on an application form or a passport.

But somewhere along the way, I realised that the real impact of ICC isn't measured by the number of events we conduct.

It's measured by the people those events bring together.

It's measured by the nervous student who walks into a room not knowing anyone and walks out with friends.

It's measured by the feeling of belonging.

And in a world that often seems determined to divide people into categories, nationalities, and labels, I think that's something worth celebrating.

The lessons I've gained through ICC are lessons that no classroom could have fully taught.

I've learned how to communicate with people from different backgrounds.

I've learned how to adapt when things don't go according to plan, which, as anyone involved in organisations knows, happens more often than we'd like.

But as I stand here today, I realise this speech isn't really about my journey.

It's about yours.

Because in a few weeks, many of you will be sitting in classrooms, joining clubs, attending your first events, meeting people who are complete strangers today, and slowly building a university experience that is entirely your own.

And while all of that may seem distant right now, it often begins much sooner, and much smaller than we expect.

If you push one piece of a Domino today, you won't feel that anything significant has happened

One tiny piece falls.

That's it.

But if that domino happens to be the first in a line, it can set hundreds more in motion.

Looking back, joining ICC felt a lot like pushing that first domino.

And it can be yours too

At the time, it didn't feel like a life-changing decision.

Just a committee.

Nothing extraordinary.

But that one decision led to friendships I never expected, opportunities I never imagined, experiences I never planned for, and lessons I know I will carry with me for years to come.

And that's why, to all the students beginning their journey today, my advice is simple.

Don't underestimate the small decisions.

Because as I look around this room today, I see something exciting.

I see stories that haven't happened yet.

Friendships that haven't been formed yet.

Opportunities that haven't been taken yet.

Memories that haven't been made yet.

And maybe that's the best part.

Because the moments that shape us rarely announce themselves as important.

Most of the time, they arrive disguised as something ordinary.

A conversation.

A meeting.

A chance encounter.

Or perhaps, a family i like to call The International Christie Community..

Thank you and welcome to ICC.